

Into the stomach

The stomach mixes chewed food with gastric juice, a liquid that contains an enzyme (chemical digester) that breaks down proteins. The stomach also stores food, releasing it slowly so that the small intestine has time to digest it.

The **esophagus** delivers food from the mouth

Muscular bag

The baglike stomach has a stretchy wall so that it can expand during a meal. The wall has three layers of muscles that contract to squash and squeeze the food, churning it up and mixing it with the gastric juice.

The **duodenum** is the first part of the small intestine

Folds in the stomach lining disappear as it fills with food

The **pyloric sphincter** is a ring of muscle that remains tightly closed when the stomach processes food.

Chyme is a mixture of part-digested food and gastric juice

